

Effects of Standards on Common People

Unmasking aesthetic standards

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ABSTRACT

This report addresses the arbitrary aesthetic benchmarks imposed on everyday individuals across society. In many communities, unrealistic physical expectations, hyper-curated social media standards, media tropes, and deep-rooted colorism create hostile environments for both men and women. Media portrayals—ranging from classic animated cartoons to modern cinema and modeling—have long reinforced severe biases by framing virtue through extreme "hourglass" silhouettes while vilifying rectangular frames, darker skin tones, and unconventional features. Young women are routinely overlooked, downgraded in professional or social settings, and subjected to public harassment. Simultaneously, young men and adolescents face mounting pressure to achieve unattainable physiques, driving many toward body dysmorphia and dangerous performance-enhancing drug (PED) abuse. By examining everyday peer dynamics alongside real-world cases involving prominent figures such as Samantha Ruth Prabhu, Rashmika Mandanna, and Ileana D'Cruz, this report exposes the real-world physical and psychological harm of these prejudices and offers an empowering call to action: shifting focus toward character, intellect, and genuine capability over superficial physical traits.

1. INTRODUCTION

Every day, ordinary people navigate unwritten societal rules that attempt to measure human worth through physical appearance. While beauty standards have historically targeted women through narrow media ideals—from classic Disney character designs to high-fashion runways—modern social media culture has rapidly amplified these appearance-based pressures across all gender spectrums.

Girls and women, particularly those with darker skin tones or non-conforming builds, continue to be disproportionately subjected to colorism and body shaming across classrooms, workplaces, family gatherings, and digital platforms. Simultaneously, young men face an unprecedented wave of muscle dysmorphia, driven by online fitness culture and impossible aesthetic benchmarks. This report aims to expose these unfair realities, reject the false notion that complexion or physique determines value, and deliver a clear message: true worth lies in character, skill, integrity, and human potential.

2. DETAILED ANALYSIS

2.1 The Daily Toll: Media Tropes, Colorism, Skinny Shaming, and Social Invisible Walls

Superficial standards are deeply ingrained in daily interactions and popular media, causing lasting psychological harm through subtle degradation and overt discrimination.

- **Media Tropes and the "Hourglass vs. Villainess" Dichotomy:**

- **The Idealized Heroine Silhouette:** From classic Disney princesses to mainstream film and modeling, virtue and desirability are overwhelmingly tied to an exaggerated, hyper-feminine hourglass figure. Audiences are conditioned from early childhood to associate thin waists, symmetrical features, and fair complexions with purity, goodness, and success.
- **The Caricatured Villainess:** Conversely, media narratives—most notably across classic animated films—frequently rely on visual shorthand to code evil or undesirable traits. Antagonists and villainesses are routinely drawn with boxy or rectangular physiques, harsh angular faces, and noticeably darker or unnatural skin tones. This subtle conditioning embeds deep-rooted biases against people whose bodies or complexions do not conform to soft, conventional ideals.
- **The Reality of Colorism (Darker Skin Tones):**
 - **Social & Familial Bias:** Girls with darker complexions frequently face casual remarks, unsolicited "fairness" advice, and subtle exclusion in social circles, creating an artificial sense of inferiority reinforced by media representation.
 - **Professional Downgrading:** In interviews and client-facing roles, color bias often leads employers or peers to unfairly judge capability based on skin tone rather than merit, skill, or qualifications.
- **The Reality of Skinny Shaming (Leaner Builds):**
 - **Mockery Disguised as Banter:** Girls with leaner physical builds are routinely subjected to intrusive comments about their weight, health, or appearance, reducing their identity to physical volume.
 - **The "Invisibility" Effect:** Society often overlooks women who do not fit traditional, voluptuous, or perfectly proportioned beauty curves, treating them as lesser or less capable in social spaces.
- **Psychological & Emotional Impact:** Constant exposure to media stereotypes, colorism, and body shaming drives young women into severe self-doubt, social anxiety, body dysmorphia, and clinical depression.
- **Real-World Case Study 1 (Ileana D'Cruz):** Having publicly discussed her lifelong battle with body dysmorphia and early-onset body shaming since age 15, Ileana's experience reflects what millions of young girls endure—internalizing cruel peer comments and media standards until self-worth is entirely compromised.
- **Real-World Case Study 2 (Samantha Ruth Prabhu):** While managing myositis (an autoimmune condition), Samantha faced invasive public comments and online body-shaming regarding her weight fluctuations and physical exhaustion, proving how society prioritizes aesthetic conformity over underlying health and humanity.

2.2 Cyber Harassment, AI Misuse, Male Fitness Standards, and Anabolic Steroid Abuse

(Focus Area: Student 2)

When casual judgment moves into digital and public spheres, it rapidly mutates from social exclusion into severe safety threats, dignity violations, and dangerous health crises.

- **Digital Harassment and Colorist Trolling:** Online comment sections frequently become hubs for colorist remarks and targeted harassment against dark-skinned female content creators, student leaders, and professionals.
- **Misuse of Generative AI (Deepfakes):** Synthetic media tools are increasingly weaponized to violate women's digital safety and consent. Non-consensual deepfakes and altered images are created specifically to humiliate, intimidate, and force women out of public digital spaces.
- **Victim Blaming and Social Control:** Whenever an ordinary woman faces street harassment or digital abuse, societal standards reflexively shift accountability onto her—questioning her attire, character, or presence in public environments instead of holding perpetrators accountable.
- **Escalating Male Fitness Standards and Social Media Pressure:** Short-form video algorithms routinely push hyper-muscular, impossibly lean physiques to teenage boys and young men. Constant exposure to edited, well-lit, and often enhanced fitness influencers distorts reality, making natural progression seem inadequate and creating widespread muscle dysmorphia (often termed "bigorexia").
- **Adolescent Steroid Abuse and the Fallacy of the "Genetic Maximum":** Driven by the fear that their natural genetic potential will never measure up to algorithm-driven ideals, impressionable adolescents are increasingly resorting to androgenic-anabolic steroids (AAS) and SARM compounds. Many young lifters blindly follow influencers, hopping on dangerous cycles long before ever reaching their natural training limits, risking permanent hormone suppression, severe cardiovascular damage, and mental health crises.
- **Real-World Case Study 1 (Rashmika Mandanna):** In late 2023, a viral AI-generated deepfake video altering Rashmika's likeness demonstrated how easily modern technology is abused to violate a woman's consent and reputation.
- **Real-World Case Study 2 (Public Trolling of Female Athletes & Unrealistic Male Benchmarks):** Prominent female athletes face public mockery whenever their muscle mass fails to conform to soft, traditional beauty ideals, while male fitness creators who secretly use performance-enhancing drugs sell fake lifestyle advice and workouts to impressionable youth, normalizing dangerous substance reliance under the guise of "hard work."

3. STRATEGIES TO ESCAPE: DOS AND DON'TS OF BREAKING FREE

To break free from the burden of societal standards, individuals must adopt specific protective actions while actively avoiding traps that reinforce the same cycle.

3.1 Constructive Actions to Escape Societal Pressure (What to Do)

- **Adopt Body & Complexion Neutrality:** Shift internal focus from how the body looks to what the mind and body accomplish. Valuing physical health, resilience, intellect, and character neutralizes the impact of external judgment and media tropes.
- **Practice Digital Hygiene and Media Curation:** Unfollow accounts, media channels, and fitness influencers that promote colorism, extreme beauty ideals, fake natural transformations, or outrage culture. Actively curate media consumption to focus on realistic, diverse representation and substance over aesthetic perfection.

- **Set Zero-Tolerance Digital & Social Boundaries:** Use privacy tools, block features, reporting mechanisms, and legal avenues against cyberbullying, colorist abuse, and non-consensual deepfakes rather than attempting to appease bullies.
- **Call Out Casual Shaming and PED Normalization in Daily Life:** Interrupt appearance-based gossip, skin-tone jokes, media stereotypes, or the casual normalization of steroid and SARM use within peer groups to foster healthier, ground-truth environments.

3.2 Harmful Pitfalls and Reactions to Avoid (What NOT to Do)

- **DO NOT Seek Validation Through Extreme Alteration or Dangerous Compounds:** Avoid relying on dangerous skin-lightening products, crash diets, or extreme physical modifications—especially illegal anabolic steroids or unvetted performance enhancers—solely to gain external approval or match media standards.
- **DO NOT Engage in Counter-Shaming:** Never respond to judgment by insulting an abuser's physical traits or training progress. Counter-shaming legitimizes the false idea that physical appearance determines human value.
- **DO NOT Internalize Blame or Self-Censor:** Avoid stepping back from career ambitions, leadership roles, or public spaces out of fear of criticism. Shrinking oneself to avoid judgment grants bullies, media tropes, and algorithms control over your life.
- **DO NOT Isolate Yourself:** Avoid absorbing trauma or body image struggles in silence. When dealing with severe body dysmorphia, online harassment, or social anxiety, reach out to trusted peers, professional counselors, medical experts, or legal authorities.

5. CONCLUSION

Complexion, height, muscle mass, and physical build do not determine human worth. Girls with darker skin tones, individuals with non-traditional body types, and young men struggling with body image are in no way inferior to anyone else; their potential, dignity, and intelligence are complete as they are. As a society, we must stop evaluating people through superficial filters, outdated cinematic tropes, and algorithmically manipulated beauty ideals. Whether hiring for a job, choosing a friend, or working in a team, the true measure of a person lies in their character, skill, integrity, and resilience—never in their skin tone or physical shape.